Red-state victories will create a more diverse Democratic Party

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Democrats' midterm victories in Sun Belt and Plains states where they had not won in a generation or where candidates dramatically outperformed polling will make the party more diverse ideologically, geographically, and demographically.
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This diversity will make the party less dependent on its base of Black and college-educated white voters and force it to focus on pocketbook issues over the next two years while incorporating a broad array of stances on hot-button issues like AI.
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The stocks of moderates in the party, especially Senator Jon Ossoff (D-GA), have risen the most, but progressives will also see the results—especially in Michigan and Florida—as vindication of their view that they can win in swing states, setting up a crowded presidential primary for 2028.

The midterms were a major victory for Democratic moderates. The scale of the Democratic victory was far more impressive in Sun Belt states than in northern, more industrial/agricultural ones: Georgia, North Carolina, and Texas all went for Democrats by double-digit margins, while those in Ohio, Maine, Wisconsin, Michigan, and Iowa were narrower. Democrats won by more in the South than in their traditional Northeast heartlands, a reversal of the pattern that has characterized the last three presidential elections.

Victory in the South and Plains was driven by moderate candidates; not a single Democratic winner there counts as a progressive, and figures such as Adam Hamilton of Kansas or Josh Turek of Iowa will likely be among the furthest-right members of the Democratic Senate caucus.

Ossoff's stock has risen most. Senator Jon Ossoff (D-GA) romped to victory by nearly 20 points, considerably outperforming his polls and carrying Democrats to victory on his coattails across the state; he has now won twice in the swing state of Georgia, an impressive electoral feat under any

circumstances. Following this performance, the steady current of Ossoff 2028 hype will likely grow into a torrent over the coming month, and he should now be seen as in the very top tier of Democratic presidential candidates.

Other figures whose stock has risen after the midterms include Governor Josh Shapiro of Pennsylvania, who easily won a second term in a swing state; Governor Wes Moore of Maryland, an exemplar of the party's youthful moderate bloc; and outgoing Governor Gretchen Whitmer of Michigan, another moderate. California Governor Gavin Newsom and former vice president Kamala Harris still lead in early polling of the primary, but the ascendance of a new generation suggests those leads will probably shrink in the new year.

Every Democrat looks stronger, but moderates look strongest. Democrats won by enough, across every competitive state, that every faction in the party can draw positive takeaways. Progressives will interpret Abdul El-Sayed's victory in Michigan as evidence that progressives can win in swing states. For progressives who have held their noses—out of a concern over electability—to vote for moderate figures in recent presidential primaries, his victory will serve as justification for supporting a progressive candidate in the next primary. This dynamic will boost the stock of Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-NY) if she chooses to run and Rep. Ro Khanna (D-CA) as the progressive replacement if she does not. Meanwhile, the "core" of the party—Black voters and college-educated urban whites—is still moving to the left: Los Angeles and Washington, DC, both elected mayors affiliated with the Democratic Socialists of America, and the far-left group in the House Democratic caucus will be larger than ever before.

The risk for progressives is that they are reading too much into El-Sayed's victory, however; unlike Ossoff in Georgia, James Talarico in Texas, or Hamilton in Kansas, candidates who substantially outperformed their states' fundamentals, El-Sayed's seven-point victory wasn't electorally impressive. In Florida, Democratic Socialist Angie Nixon came within three points of victory but again did not outperform the national swing. A progressive presidential nominee would still probably underperform a more moderate one in swing states.

On net, the Democratic Party that emerges from the midterms will be a more diverse one. National Democrats adopted a largely laissez-faire posture on the key races this year, letting candidates like Scott Colom in Mississippi or Talarico in Texas craft their own messages, better-tailored to the constituencies they needed to win. Red-state success this year suggests Democrats might be more willing over the next two years to lean into locally flavored diversity.

That will lead to a more diverse, barbell-shaped party, containing larger moderate and progressive factions, more competitive outside its traditional heartlands while still leaning into progressivism in coastal states and urban areas. Into 2028, expect the Democratic Party to act more like the "big tent" it was during the George W. Bush and Barack Obama presidencies—when it included senators from Montana, Missouri, North Dakota, and Louisiana—rather than the more ideologically uniform party of the first Donald Trump and Joe Biden administrations. In response, Democrats will focus more on pocketbook issues without a strong partisan valence, such as affordability, healthcare, and housing, and will lean towards less doctrinaire stances on some issues, such as AI.

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